

Q What is the best way to sanitize bottles and nipples for my baby?

It's good to know that there are a few different safe methods you can use to sanitize baby feeding equipment, rather a single correct way.

Before sanitizing, wash bottles, nipples, and the equipment used to make up your baby's formula thoroughly in hot, soapy water to remove all traces of milk residue. This is easier to do soon after a feeding, and using a bottle brush to clean the crevices. Rinse off the detergent. Parts from breast pumps should be washed this way after each use and then sanitized according to the manufacturer's instructions.

Washing alone does not kill harmful bacteria and viruses, so the bottles, nipples, and related equipment need to be sanitized. Cold-water sanitization involves submerging the equipment in cold water treated with a chemical agent, which comes in tablet or liquid form. Leave the equipment covered in the solution for at least 30 minutes before use, to keep it sanitized.

Steam sanitizers range from quick-to-use microwave steamers to electric sanitizers. Place the openings of bottles and nipples face down so that the insides are sanitized by rising steam.

To boil the equipment, immerse the items completely in a large, lidded pan of water. Boil for at least 10 minutes to kill germs, and keep the lid on the pan until equipment is needed.

Boiling nipples can wear them out quicker, so check for signs of damage before using them.

Q How much formula does my baby need each day? Does it depend on his appetite, or should I stick to a set amount?

In the first week or so, just like a breast-fed baby, your baby will probably manage just small amounts of formula at each feeding. After this, and until about six months of age, the rule of thumb is to give 2.5 ounces of formula a day for every pound of body weight.

Q Is there a certain way I should make up my baby's bottles?

There is a particular method that you must follow each time you make up a powdered formula bottle for your baby (see below).

Special care needs to be taken when making up formula for two reasons. One is that cartons of formula powder, although sealed, are not sterile (unlike ready-to-drink cartons of formula, which are), so could contain bacteria such as salmonella that could make your baby extremely ill. This means that meticulous hygiene is paramount when making up bottles. Secondly, the ratio of

powder to milk needs to be exactly right to make sure your baby is getting the correct balance of nutrients. Too little powder can mean that your baby isn't getting enough nourishment; and too much powder could make your baby constipated and dehydrated. Always read the manufacturer's instructions carefully before you begin and make up a bottle using the scoop provided.



Be precise It's vital that you follow the manufacturer's instructions when making up powdered formula.

STEPS TO MAKING UP POWDERED FORMULA

Here are the steps to follow each time you make up a bottle. You'll soon get the hang of it and will be able to follow the steps effortlessly. However, you must continue to be stringent with the process.



1 Start by boiling a quart (1 liter) of fresh tap water (rather than water sitting in a kettle). Let the water cool for no more than 30 minutes so that it is at least 158° F (70° C)—hot enough to kill off any bacteria present.



2 Wash your hands thoroughly and make sure the surface where you are preparing the bottle is scrupulously clean. You can spray the area with antibacterial spray and wipe it down before you start to make up a bottle.



3 Put the water in the bottle first, pouring in the exact amount recommended by the manufacturer on the packaging. Don't dilute or strengthen the formula because it can affect your baby's digestive system.



4 Using the scoop provided, loosely scoop out some formula, then level this off with a clean, dry knife, or with the leveler provided, and add the specified number of scoops to the water. Always use the scoop that came with the formula.



5 Holding the nipple by its edge, push it through the retaining ring, screw the ring onto the bottle, and cover with the cap. Shake the bottle so that all the powder dissolves. Let the formula cool before you give it to your baby.



6 Test the temperature on the inside of your wrist to help you gauge whether it's ready for your baby: it should be just warm, but not hot. To cool it down, place the bottle in a bowl of cold water or run the bottom half of the bottle under a cold faucet.